SPORTS

INDIA'S TOP MEDAL CONTENDERS AT CWG

India is a rising force in sport, as demonstrated by their best-ever haul of seven medals at last year's Tokyo Olympics. Another step in the journey for the country's athletes will be the Commonwealth Games, which will take place in Birmingham from July 28-August 8. India is competing in 15 sports at the Games and here are the athletes poised for a podium finish:

WOMEN'S CRICKET TEAM

The Indian women's cricket team, which has consistently been on the up in the past five years, will represent the country at a multi-sport event for the first time. Women's T20 cricket is set to debut at the CWG in Birmingham and India have sent to the UK a strong squad, led by Harmanpreet Kaur. Since cricket is predominantly played in Commonwealth countries, it is expected to be very competitive. India is in Group A, along with Australia, Pakistan and Barbados. The eight-team event also includes England, Sri Lanka, South Africa and New Zealand.



G. SATHIYAN AND MANIKA BATRA

(Table Tennis)

At the 2018 CWG, India won eight medals, including three golds, to finish as the top nation in table tennis. While the men's and women's teams won gold, Manika Batra claimed gold in women's singles. Batra and G. Sathiyan, who will compete in mixed doubles, will lead India's hopes. They won the WTT Contender title in Budapest in 2021 and were the first Indian pair to make QF of a World Championship last year.

BAJRANG PUNIA

(Wrestling)

After failing to match his own expectations in Tokyo, where he won a bronze, Bajrang Punia is hoping to return to his best in Birmingham. He won a gold medal in the previous CWG edition. Punia, World No. 5 in the 65kg category, has recovered from a knee injury that hampered him in Tokyo. He won a bronze medal at Bolat Turlykhanov Cup in June. Wrestling is not the most competitive CWG sport, and India is expected to win a medal in almost all 12 categories they have entered.

P.V. SINDHU

(Badminton)

India's most consistent performer in big events in recent times, P.V. Sindhu is taregting her first gold at CWG in women's singles. She had lost to Saina Nehwal in the singles final in 2018. The two-time Olympic medalist announced her return to form by winning the Singapore Open in July. While Sindhu is the spearhead, the recent Thomas Cup win has raised hopes from India's male players–Kidambi Srikanth and Lakshya Sen in men's singles and Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty in men's doubles as well.

AVINASH SABLE

(Steeplechase, Athletics)

In the past five years, Avinash Sable has consistently raised the bar in his pet event–the 3,000m steeplechase–in India. Having broken the national record eight times, Sable's best now stands at 8:12.48 minutes. He qualified for the final at the recently-concluded World Championships in Oregon, but finished 11th with a time of 8.31.75 seconds, his slowest since October 2019. Competing in his first CWG, the Indian athlete will have stiff competition from Kenyan runners.



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